files reveal Chilean emigrants were primarily members of the intelligentsia, students, employees, educators, officials and artists.)

Amid the carnage in Santiago, Honecker managed to have Leo Yanez Betancourt plucked from the notorious Dawson's Island prison in Chile. Betancourt, a young communist activist, had been dating Sonja Honecker while studying in Dresden in 1972 but had returned home to help in the forthcoming elections. Having been briefly detained by Pinochet's henchmen, Honecker – at the insistence of his sobbing daughter – successfully secured his release.

By way of reply, the GDR agreed to continue business ties with the new Pinochet regime, and eight employees of East Germany's Ministry of Foreign Trade remained in Santiago. As for Betancourt, he was spirited to East Berlin to resume his romance with Sonja. The following year, the couple presented Erich and Margot with a grandson, Roberto.

From then on, the bond between father and daughter grew closer. The Yanez family was installed on the thirteenth floor of a tower block at Leipziger Straße 55 in the centre of Berlin, and Sonja's career blossomed modestly7 as a secretary for agitation and propaganda in the FDJ Berlin district leadership.8 Thoroughly spoiled, Honecker gave his daughter everything he never had. According to Heinz Lippmann's anecdotal evidence, Sonja had enjoyed a privileged childhood, pampered and sheltered from everyday hardships. For example, during her studies at an institute in Halle specialising in preparing students for study abroad, her father sent an official chauffeured car to whisk her home every weekend, although her fellow students were only allowed leave once a month.9

Sonja's marriage though was a difficult union; Leo was calm and even-tempered, while she could be restless and nervous – she never adapted to the cultural differences between Germany and Chile.10

As for Erica, Honecker's first daughter with Edith Baumann, she married SED functionary Karl Wildau, a future GDR ambassador to the Netherlands.